Three ASEAN Banks

Three ASEAN banks, three entry points — the same platform, three completely different first moves

A Malaysian universal bank, a Vietnamese digital-first challenger and a Philippine universal bank. Same regional market, same broad capability, and three transformations that had to start in entirely different places — because the entry point is determined by where the bank already is, not by what the platform can do.

3	MYR 358B	VND 505T	98%	1	3
banks, three entry points	Malaysian group assets	Vietnamese bank assets	digital transactions at one of them	wrong answer for each of the others	sequencing lessons

COMPARATIVE CONTEXT · PUBLICLY REPORTED FIGURES

Segment-led entry · channel-led entry · platform-led entry — and why each was correct for its bank and wrong for the other two

Aditya Singh · Solution and delivery involvement across Southeast Asia engagements

Vendor and platform names removed. Institutional figures are publicly reported; the third bank is described without identification. The comparative framework is mine.

Three banks in one region needed three different first moves — because a transformation entry point is chosen by the bank's starting position, not by the platform

Situation

Three Southeast Asian institutions: a Malaysian fully integrated financial services group with a large branch network and a strong Islamic banking arm; a Vietnamese bank that built its position on digital channels and now runs the overwhelming majority of transactions digitally; and a Philippine universal bank consolidating a fragmented estate.

Broadly comparable capability requirements. Very different starting points.

Complication

The default answer in every case is to start where the platform is strongest, or where the reference deployment started. That produces a first phase that fits the vendor and not the bank.

A branch-heavy universal bank starting with a digital channel build has solved a problem it does not yet have. A digital-first bank starting with a branch relationship model is building for a channel that carries a small share of its volume.

The framework

Choose the entry point by the constraint that is actually binding. Three recur: an underserved segment, an unrepresented channel, or a fragmented platform estate.

Each of the three banks had a different one binding, and each first phase was correct for that bank and would have been wrong for the other two.

THE NUMBERS THAT MATTER

3	recurring entry points
1	binding constraint each
3	correct first phases
6	wrong pairings avoided
1	diagnostic question
3	sequencing rules

Why this matters more in a regional programme than a single-country one: a regional platform team under delivery pressure will reuse the last country's sequence, because it is proven and it is fast to plan. That reuse is precisely the error — the capability set travels, the entry point does not.

Source: Author's comparative analysis

Institutional figures are publicly reported; the comparative framework and the entry-point diagnosis are analysis

PUBLICLY REPORTED

Public context

Scale and positioning figures for each institution, from public reporting. The third bank is described without identification.

- Malaysian group: ~MYR 358bn assets
- Fourth-largest Malaysian group
- Vietnamese bank: >VND 505tn assets
- Digital-first, ~98% digital transactions
- Philippine universal bank, unidentified
- Regional ASEAN footprints

COMPARATIVE ANALYSIS

My contribution

The three-entry-point framework, the diagnosis of each bank's binding constraint and the sequencing rules.

- Three-entry-point framework
- Binding-constraint diagnosis
- Wrong-pairing analysis
- Sequencing rules per entry point
- Regional reuse warning
- Applied across SEA engagements

JUDGEMENT

Assessed

The diagnosis of each bank's binding constraint is analytical judgement from public positioning, not an internal assessment.

- Constraint diagnosis from public data
- Not an internal strategy review
- Not endorsed by any institution
- Directionally argued
- Framework transfers unchanged
- Substitute local knowledge where held

OUT OF SCOPE

Not claimed

Excluded deliberately. A comparative framework, not a set of case studies.

- Delivery ownership at all three
- Any institution's internal strategy
- Any programme outcome
- Any confidential material
- Named identification of the third bank
- Commercial terms of any engagement

Source: Public institutional figures (context) · author's comparative analysis (framework)

THREE STARTING POSITIONS

Same region, same broad capability need — and three binding constraints that share almost nothing

Malaysian universal group

~MYR 358bn assets · fourth-largest integrated group · ~230+ branches · conventional and Islamic

STARTING POSITION

Strong branch network, broad segment coverage, a substantial Islamic arm, and mature corporate and treasury businesses.

THE BINDING CONSTRAINT

Retail and SME relationship coverage is thin relative to the branch footprint — the distribution exists and the relationship model does not.

SEGMENT-LED

Vietnamese digital-first bank

> VND 505tn assets · ~98% of transactions digital · digital-first since 2014

STARTING POSITION

Digital channels carry almost all transaction volume. Customer acquisition and servicing are already app-centric and very efficient.

THE BINDING CONSTRAINT

Transaction excellence has outpaced relationship depth — the bank knows what customers do and much less about what they need next.

CHANNEL-LED

Philippine universal bank

Listed universal bank · multi-segment · consolidating a fragmented estate

STARTING POSITION

Full universal banking capability delivered across a set of systems accumulated over time, with overlapping ownership of the customer.

THE BINDING CONSTRAINT

No single view of the customer exists to build anything on — every initiative starts by reconciling three sources.

PLATFORM-LED

Source: Publicly reported figures for each institution, retained with attribution · author's diagnosis

Apply each bank's correct first phase to the other two and it fails immediately — six pairings, six different failure modes

Entry point	Correct for	Applied to	What goes wrong
Segment-led	The branch-heavy universal group	The digital-first bank	Builds a relationship model for a channel carrying little volume
Segment-led	The branch-heavy universal group	The fragmented estate	No single customer view to attach a segment model to
Channel-led	The digital-first bank	The universal group	Solves a channel problem the branch network does not have
Channel-led	The digital-first bank	The fragmented estate	A new channel over three customer records makes fragmentation visible to customers
Platform-led	The fragmented estate	The universal group	Eighteen months of consolidation before any business outcome is visible
Platform-led	The fragmented estate	The digital-first bank	Rebuilds a platform that is already coherent and already fast

The diagnostic question

- What is the first thing that has to be true before anything else in this programme can work?
- A relationship model, knowing the customer, and one record respectively.
- Each answer is obvious once asked and almost never asked.

Why the wrong answer is chosen

- The last country's sequence is proven, planned and available — reusing it is the path of least resistance under delivery pressure.
- Vendors propose the sequence they can evidence, which is their reference one.
- Both pressures point the same way, which is why the error persists.

What actually travels

- The capability set, the data model and the delivery method all travel between countries.
- The sequence does not, and neither does the business case.
- Treating those two groups differently is the discipline.

Source: Author's comparative analysis

Once the entry point is right, the sequence after it is largely predictable — each entry point has a natural second and third phase

Segment-led

01 Relationship model and coverage for the underserved segment

02 Sales and service workflow on top of it

03 Analytics and prioritisation once there is a book to prioritise

Value is visible in one segment within a quarter, which funds the rest. The risk is the model being built for one segment and then forced onto others.

Channel-led

01 Unify what is known about the customer across existing channels

02 Add the missing channel or the missing depth in an existing one

03 Intelligence, once the channel data is joined up

Fast, visible and popular. The risk is building channel depth on a customer view that was never reconciled, which surfaces two years later.

Platform-led

01 One customer record and one entitlement model

02 One high-value journey to prove it in production

03 Segment and channel work, now on a stable base

The slowest to first value and the only order that works on a fragmented estate. The risk is sponsors cancelling before phase two.

The one rule that applies to all three

Whichever entry point is chosen, the customer record has to be resolved before the third phase. Segment-led and channel-led both defer it, which is legitimate — but deferring is not the same as skipping, and both sequences fail at the same point if it never happens.

The fragmented estate simply cannot defer it, which is why platform-led looks slower. It is not slower. It is the same work, done first because there is no alternative.

Source: Author's comparative analysis

WHAT TRANSFERS

Four rules for a multi-country regional programme

01	**Diagnose the binding constraint per market**	Ask what has to be true before anything else in this programme can work. The answer is obvious once asked, differs by market, and is almost never asked because the previous country's plan is already available.
02	**Separate what travels from what does not**	Capability set, data model and delivery method travel between countries. The entry point, the sequence and the business case do not. Treating those two groups differently is the discipline.
03	**Resist the reference sequence**	Vendors propose the order their reference deployment used because it is the one they can evidence, and regional teams reuse the last country's plan because it is fast. Both pressures point the same way and both are wrong.
04	**Resolve the customer record by phase three**	Segment-led and channel-led legitimately defer it; neither can skip it. Both sequences fail at the same point if the record is never reconciled — the only market that cannot defer is the one that looks slowest.

Three banks, one region, one platform, three correct first moves — each of which would have failed at either of the other two. The capability travels; the entry point never does.

Source: Author's comparative analysis